

ODISHA A LAND OF Heritage

Culture and Natural Beauty

Odisha is a state rich in history, culture and natural resources. Known for its ancient temples, classical dance, tribal traditions and scenic landscapes, Odisha offers a unique blend of the tradition and the modernity. The state's historical significance is still evident in its numerous archaeological sites, ancient monuments and temples.

Historically, Odisha was known at different times by different names like Kalinga, Utkal, Udra Desh, Toshali etc. throughout its long past. These ancient names reflect different periods of history, dynasties and cultural influences. They highlight Odisha's importance as a cultural, religious and political centre in Indian history. The government appropriately depicts the state as "India's hidden gem ". Despite its rich cultural heritage, natural beauty and unique traditions, the state remains less explored and less commercialised compared to other popular tourist destinations in India. Its unspoiled charm and hidden treasures make it a gem waiting to be discovered.

One of the most iconic landmarks of Odisha is the Sun Temple at Konark, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Built in the 13th century, this chariot-shaped temple is a masterpiece of Kalinga architecture. Equally famous as the Shri Jagannath Temple in Puri, one of the Char Dham pilgrim sites for Hindus. The annual 'Rath Yatra' or chariot festival held here attracts millions of devotees from across the globe.

'Odia' is one of the oldest languages in India with a literary history dating back to over 1,000 years. It was granted 'Classical Language' status by the Government of India in 2014, acknowledging its rich literary and historical tradition. Odia is known for its sweetness, melodic tone, poetic quality and deep connection to the cultural and spiritual life of Odisha. Odisha is also known for its classical dance form 'Odissi', which is one of the eight recognised classical dance styles of India. With its intricate movements, graceful expressions and deeply spiritual themes, Odissi has its roots in the temple rituals of the region.

The state is home to over 60 diverse tribal communities, each with its own distinct language, customs, dances and crafts and art forms, contributing to the rich cultural mosaic of Odisha. The tribal art, handlooms and Pattachitra paintings are quite vibrant.

Geographically, Odisha boasts a diverse landscape that includes coastal plains, fertile river valleys, hills and forests. The state is home to several wildlife sanctuaries and national parks such as Simlipal, Asia's largest brackish water lagoon Chilika Lake and Bhitarkanika, making it a haven for nature and wildlife lovers.

Economically, Odisha is rich in minerals and is one of India's top producers of iron ore, coal and bauxite. The state has also been developing its infrastructure and industrial sectors, with a focus on IT, manufacturing and renewable energy.

With its deep-rooted heritage, natural beauty and growing economy, Odisha stands as a vibrant and evolving state, offering both serenity and dynamism to those who want to explore it.

Its unspoiled charm and hidden treasures make it a gem waiting to be discovered. This makes it ideal for travellers seeking offbeat and meaningful experiences.